



COMMITTEE OF THE WHOLE (PUBLIC)

4 March 2025

Report No. 25-016

Comprehensive Report on the Elementary Program Review: Proposed Attendance Boundaries, Grade Configurations and Program Offerings

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PURPOSE:

1. The comprehensive report provides an outline of the proposed changes to attendance boundaries, grade configurations and program offerings for each of the District's elementary schools as part of the program review at the elementary level. It also provides additional context with respect to transitional provisions, including plans for phasing out existing programs. This report accompanies the previous report, shared earlier this calendar year, in regard to the proposed program model and support for students

STRATEGIC LINKS:

2. The OCDSB's Strategic Plan for 2023-2027 makes a strong commitment to improving program quality and accessibility. The desire and need to review current elementary programming, service delivery and support structures emerged as recurring themes during the strategic planning process consultation in the winter and spring of 2023, as described in [Report 23-029, 2023-2027 Strategic Plan Consultation Report](#). Specifically, there were concerns expressed about inequities in accessing programs, particularly French Immersion (FI), at community schools and inconsistent support for special education across programs.

CONTEXT:

3. **Elementary Program Review To Date**
Launched in April 2024, the Elementary Program Review (EPR) is the first of a four-part, multi-year 'vision exercise' being undertaken by the District to ensure inclusive, high-quality and accessible programs and/or services offered, system-wide. The first phase of the EPR involved a community engagement campaign during which the District sought input from the community and key internal stakeholders through in-person and on-line sessions held between April and June 2024 ([Report 24-101, Consultation Report on the Elementary Program](#)

[Review](#)). Other key information sources, including District-level data and externally relevant research, were also reviewed ([Report 24-110, Contextual Report for the Elementary Program Review: District Data and Relevant Research](#)).

Informed by the three key information sources (public consultation, relevant research and District data), a revised program model and proposed changes to supports for students were presented in January 2025 ([Report 25-002 - Comprehensive Report on the Elementary Program Review: Proposed Program Model and Support for Students](#)). This report also presented, for approval, a consultation plan to collect feedback from the OCDSB community, which is currently underway. This report provides additional information on proposed changes required to support successful implementation of the model, including school-specific information on proposed attendance boundaries, grade configurations and program offerings, by the end of February 2025, for discussion at the 4 March 2025 Committee of the Whole meeting.

4. **Current Elementary School Configurations**

The District currently operates 122 elementary schools (including one virtual school and two Special Education Centres), ranging in capacity from 175 students to 938 students, and school utilization factors (UF) that range from a low of 28% to a high of 161%. Two new schools are scheduled to open on or before September 2026, a K-6 school referred to as East Urban Community II and a new 7-12 secondary school in Riverside South.

The distance between some elementary schools, particularly in the urban core, is only half a kilometre, while other schools are located 10 kilometres or more from the closest OCDSB school. The District is made up of urban, suburban and rural communities, each with their own unique characteristics. The rural area is vast with less dense populations, while the downtown core has a variety of school sizes in close proximity serving neighbourhoods that are undergoing renewal and infill housing, but not substantial growth in the number of school-age children. The suburbs include a mix of older neighbourhoods with aging demographics as well as rapidly growing new suburban communities outside the Greenbelt. Across the District, there were almost 6,000 excess pupil places as of fall 2023, the baseline year used for the review. By the time of implementation in September 2026, it is anticipated that there will be well over 1,000 more excess spaces spread across the District.

There are currently nine different grade configurations among elementary schools: K-3, 4-8, K-4, K-5, K-6, K-8, 6-8, 7-8 and 7-12. There are also a range of program combinations, including single-track schools (e.g., English with Core French); dual-track schools (e.g., English with Core French and English French Immersion (EFI)); and triple-track schools (e.g., English with Core French, EFI and Middle French Immersion (MFI)), with each program in a school having its own distinct attendance boundary. A number of schools across the District also host one or more special education classes referred to as Specialized Program Classes (SPCs), or English as a Second Language/English Literacy Development (ESL/ELD) program classes. As a result, many elementary schools

have multiple attendance boundaries, based on grade, program or both. Feeding patterns between schools are not predictable and can result in cohorts of students leaving one school being directed to two or more schools. A number of K-6 schools, for example, split cohorts and feed to different intermediate grade schools based on geography or program. Of note, this happens even more frequently from Grade 8 to secondary school.

Approximately 70% of students choose to enroll in EFI at Grade 1. Although, somewhere between 30% and 40% of students choose to leave EFI and transition to the current English with Core French program, such that the split between EFI and English is almost even by Grade 8. MFI accounts for between 4% and 5% of enrolment, with fewer than 1% currently attending one of the District's five designated Alternative sites.

5. **Pupil Accommodation Review Guidelines (PARG) Compliance**

The Pupil Accommodation Review Guidelines (PARG) were issued by the Ministry of Education in 2018, imposing a moratorium on school closures and carefully dictating the manner in which pupil accommodation reviews (PAR) are to be conducted. The guidelines are only applicable to reviews within the parameters of a PAR as outlined in the guidelines. They do not apply to program reviews of the type currently underway in the OCDSB, even where such reviews include changes impacting on school attendance boundaries. However, even in the case of a PAR, the guidelines provide an exemption from the more onerous requirements if the review results in the movement of less than 50% of students enrolled in the school in the first year of implementation of the PAR changes. Although the EPR does not constitute a PAR under the guidelines, out of an abundance of caution, implementation of the proposed changes falls within the parameters for the exemption. This includes, where required, specific transitional provisions at some sites to meet the exemption criteria.

6. **Overarching Guiding Principles**

The EPR and the changes proposed to attendance boundaries, grade configurations and program offerings are guided by three overarching principles:

- **community based education** - the recognition of each school site as core to the community allows for the localization of programs and/or services related to learning, well-being, and social responsibility, as well as the effective and efficient operationalization of the organization as a system;
- **dynamic, bilingual teaching and learning environments** - the ability to offer programming in English and French for all students at each school site, along a continuum of bilingualism organized by subject area/discipline, allows for confidence, proficiency and achievement in both official languages; and,
- **continuum of inclusion** - the provision of support at each school site allows for an array of assistance for all students, including multilingual learners and those with special needs, with the potential for full inclusion, withdrawal assistance, and/or specialized program classes.

KEY CONSIDERATIONS:

7. **Consolidated Program Model**

The proposed model presented in January 2025 consolidates the District's current program offerings and recommends two program pathways for elementary students in grades 1 to 8: Enhanced English (EE) and French Immersion (FI). The proposed changes also include an evolved model of student support to ensure a more inclusive model for all students, in particular students with special education needs and multilingual learners, and reiterates the District's longstanding commitment to community-based schools. Successful implementation of the model means ensuring equitable access to the consolidated programs and supports for all students across the District through the creation of dual tracked, community-centred schools. This required a comprehensive review of attendance boundaries and grade configurations at all schools to achieve the desired outcomes, as outlined below.

8. **Phasing out of MFI and Alternative Programs**

The proposed program model included the discontinuation of both MFI and Alternative. For clarity, it is recommended that these programs be phased out over time, allowing students currently enrolled to participate in the programs through to completion. As a result, any changes to attendance boundaries, grade configurations and programs at sites currently offering MFI and Alternative must consider the impact of phasing out these programs.

9. **Proposed Boundaries, Grade Configurations and Program Offerings**

As outlined above, a critical aspect of the EPR involved a comprehensive review of the District's elementary schools to organize and create, to the extent possible, dual tracked, community schools. The outcome is a proposed rearrangement of attendance boundaries, grade configurations and program offerings at schools across the District that will achieve the following desired outcomes:

- Students will attend their designated community school, closer to home in most cases, learning and interacting with peers from their community;
- All schools will be dual tracked, offering both Enhanced English and French Immersion, with the exception that it was necessary to maintain a small number of single track FI schools to accommodate the traditionally higher enrolment in FI:
 - Le Phare Elementary School;
 - Mutchmor Public School;
 - Lakeview Public School;
 - Devonshire Community Public School; and,
 - Summerside Public School (K-6 FI only, 7-8 dual track EE and FI); and,
- Specialized Program Classes (SPCs) will remain where they are, provided the grade configuration continues to align. ESL and ELD support (integrated and specialized classes) will also continue in their current sites.

As is the case now, placement of those supports and programs will be reassessed and adjusted to reflect student learning needs in each school over

time. Further, space will be made available in every school to support a more integrated approach to special education delivery.

Further to the above, as part of the proposed changes, all schools remain open, with better planning and accommodation conditions that improve the learning experiences of students, as follows:

- There will be fewer grade configurations: K-3, K-6, K-8, 4-8, 7-8 and 7-12. In total, 30 schools will be impacted by a change to their grade configuration. There will be six more pairs of K-3 and 4-8 schools and although these configurations mean there is one more transition required than some alternatives, the K-3 schools feed to their partnered 4-8 school, allowing cohorts to be kept together;
- Each elementary school's grade configuration will end at the final grade of a school division, that is, at grade 3, (primary division), grade 6 (junior division), or grade 8 (intermediate division);
- There will be improved feeding patterns between schools that avoid splitting cohorts of students to different schools as they transition between schools, laying the groundwork for more coherent families of schools. This also means that where school populations within a community are split between schools, there will be more cases where all of the students transition to the next school as a group;
- There will be more balanced enrolments overall, with fewer very high or very low enrolment sites. This means increased stability overall from an enrolment/grade cohort perspective. This also means schools will be better utilized overall, with the number of schools having utilization factors (UF) between 70% and 99% increasing from 53 to 66 and the number of schools with a UF over 110% decreasing from 21 to 14;
- School attendance boundaries will be simplified, with most schools having a single boundary at full implementation of the model; and
- And, with more balanced enrolment, there should be less reliance on portables (generally), especially in older facilities and in some parts of the District.

A full list of the District's schools, including the two new schools planned to open between now and September 2026, is provided in Appendix A, Summary of Proposed Changes by School. It provides information for each school on current and proposed program offerings, grade configurations, student enrolment and utilization factors. The proposed attendance boundaries for each school are also available at [Elementary Program Review | Engage OCDSB](#) under the *Boundaries* tab.

The scope and magnitude of the changes being proposed is substantial and will transform the District's elementary schools. Given the complexity, the proposed model must be considered in its entirety. Introducing changes to any of the attendance boundary, grade configuration or program offering for an individual school will have repercussions for neighbouring schools and curtail efforts to achieve the desired outcomes, that is, community-based schools offering EE and FI at each site to the greatest extent possible.

10. **Transitional Provisions**

The proposed changes would, if approved, be implemented for September 2026. Transitional provisions, as described below, will be in place to support phasing out of existing programs and to meet the PARG exemption requirements.

- a) Middle French Immersion: As indicated above, MFI will be phased out over time, with the last cohort of Grade 4 students entering in September 2026 and completing Grade 8 by the end of the 2030-2031 school year. This timeline ensures that students currently enrolled in Grade 2 and 3 of the English program and planning to enroll in MFI would still have this opportunity. Students currently in Grade 1 would have the option to enrol in the FI program for Grade 3 in September 2026, as part of the proposed fluid entry. Most, but not all, MFI programs will remain at their current school locations during the phasing out period, with no changes to the current attendance boundaries. There are a couple of exceptions where current programs would be moved to another school and/or consolidated with an existing program. It may become necessary to consider additional program consolidation/relocation options at some point in time.
- b) Alternative: Alternative, as a distinct and separate offering, would also be phased out over time. Specifically, students currently enrolled in Alternative as of the Board decision, and any junior kindergarten (JK) students registering for September 2025, would continue in Alternative until they complete Grade 6 or, as applicable, Grade 8. For the last cohort of JK students starting in September 2025, this would be the end of the 2032-2033 school year, with those opting to continue to Grade 8 at Summit Alternative, by the end of the 2034-2035 school year. Effective September 2026, the Alternative schools begin to transition over time to either K-6 or K-3 dual track community schools, coincident with the Alternative grades phasing out. Current attendance boundaries for Alternative will remain in place during the phase out period. As with MFI, it may become necessary to look at consolidation/relocation options in future years.
- c) PARG Exemption Requirement: As indicated above, the EPR does not meet the definition of a pupil accommodation review and therefore does not trigger the PARG requirements. Notwithstanding, the PARG provides an exemption from the application of the PARG requirements provided a school maintains at least 50% of its current enrolment in the year that changes impacting attendance boundaries are implemented. The recommended changes being proposed, therefore, include transitional provisions to ensure that the 50% threshold is respected in all cases, by phasing in the implementation of some grade configurations beyond September 2026.

The transitional provisions outlined above will mean that the attendance boundaries and grade configurations for some sites will get more complex in the short term, until full implementation is achieved. There will be a few

cases where there will be anomalous grade configurations for a period of time based on the transitional provisions. For example, Riverview and Regina Street, the two Alternative sites transitioning to K-3 dual track schools, will experience a couple of years where the schools will offer K-3 EE, FI, while also maintaining grades 5 and 6 cohorts in Alternative. This is also the case with MFI. For example, Featherston Drive Public School, currently a K-8 school offering MFI, is proposed to become a dual track K-3 school. The school will maintain the MFI program as it is phased out, ultimately leading to a K-3 grade structure and a lone Grade 8 MFI cohort. Strategies will be developed through the transition implementation planning period to address these anomalous situations and ensure appropriate supports are in place for students. Given the unique circumstances that exist across the District, specific communications have been developed and shared with parents and guardians at each of the affected sites to help them better understand the impact of the transitional provisions for their children and the school.

Limitations on Additional Transitional Provisions: It has been the District's practice in the past to try and minimize the impact of program and boundary changes through the inclusion of one time exceptions, for example, one time options to remain at a site or to allow siblings to attend the same school as exceptions to the new boundary, or similar transitional provisions. However, given the complexity and scope of the changes being proposed, the plan to phase out MFI and Alternative, and the PARG exemption, any additional transitional exceptions beyond those identified above are not feasible.

11. **Implementation/Operational Considerations**

There are a number of operational and implementation issues and considerations that arise from the changes being proposed, as outlined below:

- a) Student Movement: As a result of the proposed changes to school boundaries and grade configurations, it is estimated that approximately 11,000 students may experience a change in schools for the 2026-2027 school year. In comparison, a normal year would see approximately 6,000 to 8,000 students moving schools as they transition from one grade to the next. While the increased movement is not insignificant, the disruption needs to be balanced against the reasons why the changes are being proposed and the resulting benefits of seeing the change happen for the system, moving forward.
- b) Staff Movement: The proposed changes would also impact staff, specifically, teachers, registered early childhood educators (RECEs), educational assistants (EAs) and office staff assigned to elementary schools. For example, the proposed changes will result in a higher than usual number of transfers between schools, as programming, enrolment and grade configurations are all factors that directly affect the number and/or the type of staff required in a school. As is the case with other changes impacting staff, Employee Services will work with the affected

employees and their representatives to establish processes and mitigate potential impacts of the transition.

- c) Childcare: It will be necessary to work through the proposed boundary changes and new grade configurations to determine their full impact on current and future childcare services, including those provided by third parties. It will be important to ensure that plans are in place to provide seamless transitions for children and families who currently access childcare services.
- d) Transportation: The proposed boundary changes also have the potential to positively impact transportation planning for the Ottawa Student Transportation Authority (OSTA) by reducing at least some bus runs, and by having more children able to walk to school. It will be important to share information on approved changes with OSTA as soon as possible to provide sufficient time to plan transportation based on the new attendance boundaries, grade configurations and program offerings.
- e) Low Enrolment Programs: From a planning perspective, in the short term, projecting enrolment by program and school will be more challenging. For the purposes of the review, every effort was made to establish dual track schools offering both EE and FI wherever possible, including where there is some concern that enrolment in EE may be relatively low. It is difficult to predict how the proposed model and number of dual track schools will affect program choice. As more predictable enrolment trends emerge, it may be necessary to review some schools and programs again within a few years. In the interim, it will be necessary to monitor small programs and ensure they are adequately supported.
- f) New Schools (Riverside South, East Urban Community): The two new schools scheduled to open in the next two years, currently referred to as Riverside South Secondary (RSS) and the East Urban Community Elementary School (EUC) have been included in the current review. In the case of RSS, there have already been separate consultations and Board approvals on opening grade structures and boundaries. In the case of EUC, no community consultation about the boundary, grade configuration or the program have taken place as of yet based on the timing of its approval. It was necessary to include the boundary, grade configuration (K-6) and program offerings (EE and FI) for this school because it would be impractical to conduct a separate and potentially inconsistent study involving EUC and a number of existing schools. There will be opportunities for the affected community to ask questions and voice any concerns through the EPR and leading up to the school opening currently anticipated for September 2026.
- g) School Names: In some cases, due to either program or planning changes, school names may need to be changed. For example, Goulbourn Middle School is proposed to transition from a grade 6-8 school to a JK-8 school, meaning it would need to become Goulbourn Elementary

School. As well, the schools currently designated as “Alternative” in the school name would require a change to replace “Alternative” with “Elementary”.

12. **Summary and School Locator**

If approved, the proposed changes to school boundaries, grade configurations and program offerings would be implemented effective September 2026, subject to the transitional provisions described above. The magnitude and scope of the proposed changes are significant, to be sure, and will require working closely with all stakeholders to ensure a smooth and successful transition.

In order to ensure that parents and caregivers understand the implications for their children, a specific EPR school locator has been developed which allows parents and caregivers to identify their children’s designated school as of the date of implementation, September 2026, based on home address. The locator, is available by visiting [Elementary Program Review | Engage OCDSB](#) and clicking on the *Boundaries* tab. It has been set up to reflect, to the extent possible, the transitional provisions, including the gradual phasing out of MFI and Alternative. There are, however, limitations with regard to some of the more unique aspects associated with meeting the PARG requirements. Information has been and will continue to be made available for parents and caregivers at the affected sites on how the changes will impact their children’s school/program and how they can obtain additional clarification/confirmation of their children’s designated school.

RESOURCE IMPLICATIONS:

13. The proposed changes to attendance boundaries, grade configurations and program offerings will require one-time and ongoing investment of resources. Below is a preliminary summary of resource implications that have been identified to date. Additional information will be provided as part of subsequent reports for decision-making processes.
- a) Learning resources: The expansion of dual track schools will require an investment in additional learning resources. Similarly, a change in grade configurations, for example, schools where intermediate grades are being introduced, will also require additional learning materials (resources, manipulatives, etc.). The same need for additional resources will exist at schools with proposed increases in enrolment. While every reasonable effort will be made to shift resources between schools, as needed, there are also likely to be one-time costs to ensure schools have access to what they need.
 - Site-based Renovations: As noted, some school grade configurations will change in this process. There may be a need to retrofit/resource some schools to accommodate new grade configurations and program(s). For example, to accommodate new kindergarten classes, or new intermediate grades, or dual-track programming for sites that are currently single track.

It may also be necessary to move furniture, resources and other equipment among schools to accommodate enrolment changes.

- School Names: Although not significant, changing school names will mean some additional one time costs, for example, to change signage.
- Small Programs: The reduction in program offerings will mean those being offered should be more robust. However, it is possible that some schools will have small EE enrolment, potentially resulting in less efficient staffing allocations. Similarly, the transition provisions associated with phasing out MFI and Alternative may have similar impacts and costs.

COMMUNICATION/CONSULTATION:

14. At the January 28, 2025 Board meeting, the Board approved a consultation plan for collecting feedback on the proposed model and modified support for students. The consultation is guided by the Algonquin Protocols, emphasizing the importance of respectful dialogue, active listening, open-mindedness, and diverse perspectives. The consultation is ongoing, including an online survey and in-person and virtual sessions for the community scheduled through March 2025. These sessions will provide opportunities for community members to share feedback on the proposed changes outlined previously in Report 25-002 and in this report. The engage.ocdsb.ca platform will also continue to serve as a central hub for all information related to the EPR. Staff will ensure that feedback mechanisms are as accessible and inclusive as possible, accommodating diverse communication preferences so that all voices are heard to the greatest extent possible.

GUIDING QUESTIONS:

15. The following guiding questions are provided for discussion:
 - a) How do the proposed changes to attendance boundaries, grade configurations and program offerings support and align with the guiding principles of the Elementary Program Review?
 - b) How do the proposed changes improve equitable access to programs and services?
 - c) Have the impacts of the proposed changes been adequately identified and considered fully?

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APPENDICES

Appendix A Summary of Proposed Changes by School